FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Time is a continuum, like a flowing river. Our calendars put dams on it to assess what has happened and what it may foretell for the future. When looking ahead, there are certain predictable events—elections, for example. In 2023, a series of important assembly polls line the coming months—Tripura, Meghalaya and Nagaland in February; Karnataka in the summer; the grand trifecta of Madhya Pradesh-Rajasthan-Chhattisgarh in early winter; winding up with another showstopper in Telangana. We know from experience that the import for next year's general election may be limited. Still, as Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa says in his essay, the Opposition space is no longer static—with Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra and Arvind Kejriwal's advance to national party status for his Aam Aadmi Party. The persona of Prime Minister Narendra Modi is still writ large on the firmament, but "his dominance is partly dependent on how the economy performs".

The seeds of that have been sown much earlier. India handled the pandemic better than the West, but its economic recovery faces strong headwinds. Economist Jahangir Aziz of J.P. Morgan writes, "The economic recovery, while impressive in its pace, in level remains 7 per cent below that implied by the pre-pandemic growth trend. As such, it is incomplete, and the economic loss from the pandemic is likely to be large and permanent. The government and RBI see growth this year to average 6.5-7 per cent." And he sees the world grinding towards 3 per cent growth and halving to "1.7 per cent next year". Shoring up growth under such circumstances while also tamping down on inflation is like trying to treat a clot and a haemorrhage simultaneously—running in contrary directions. How India navigates these tricky waters in Budget '23, allocating resources wisely, will be critical.



January 17, 2022

Another watershed: India will become the world's most populous nation in 2023. It will stay in that position for the rest of the century, with a massive lead over China of the kind it never had over us. "If India's per capita income also rises significantly, it could be a bigger market and economy than China by 2050," writes population expert Chinmay Tumbe. "This would give tremendous geopolitical heft...India would finally be hyphenated with the US and China" as a major power. Then, there is climate change, where the world has struggled for decades, not too successfully, to preserve our planet's ecological integrity. Former foreign secretary Shyam Saran writes: "The long-term strategy to achieve India's target of Net Zero carbon emissions by 2070, which India submitted at COP-27, is disappointing." He calls for "a completely revamped transportation strategy", with the enormous sums being spent on "constructing six-lane highways and flyovers" to be redirected to develop efficient rail and river transport. Resetting India's 1960s-vintage Green Revolution and its obsession with intensive cropping is another imperative he marks out for us.

Last year saw most of the world recovering from Covid-19, but there is still concern about whether it has been eradicated or will reappear in some mutant form. Both the health experts writing in this issue, K. Srinath Reddy of the Public Health Foundation of India and former WHO chief scientist Soumya Swaminathan, while advocating due diligence, think otherwise. Covid-19 is more "a settler come to stay than an invader that destroys and departs", writes Reddy. They urge that our energies be channelled back to the endemic killers we have ignored: multi-drug resistant tuberculosis, vector-borne nasties like malaria et al. Calling non-communicable lifestyle diseases the "major cause of premature mortality", Swaminathan calls for policy action on the "commercial determinants" of health. As actionable points, she lists "the banning of trans fats, tobacco regulation, incentivising millet consumption by making them available through the PDS, and regulating the sale of high-fat, high-salt, high-sugar food and beverages in schools".

But the symptoms of this disease are also economic and geopolitical. It seems to be 2020 redux for China particularly as the by-now-known unknown of Covid stalks it again—with implications for domestic political sentiments and beyond. Will it stay with its Wolf Warrior diplomacy? Will it court war in Taiwan or on our blurred frontiers? Will Biden's America respond with matching belligerence on the China and Russia questions?

Complex and urgent questions. A galaxy of eminent experts weigh in on India's challenges and opportunities. Ashley J. Tellis of the Carnegie Endowment gives three reasons for India to worry, despite its neutrality on Ukraine: "the interruption of Russian military spares because of sanctions; Russia's deepening reliance on China as a strategic partner; and (its) continuing enervation as a great power, which undermines India's desire for global multipolarity". Kishore Mahbubani, a Distinguished Fellow at the Asia Research Institute, NUS, finds in this very flux a "geopolitical sweet spot" for India—one where it can realise its potential as the "world's only truly independent global power". That is, if it resists the temptation to hitch its wagon to America's—because "the past 200 aberrant years of Western domination of world history is finally ending". Describing this as a "world between orders", former National Security Advisor Shivshankar Menon says India can grab its chances if it resets ties with China to pacify the LAC; joins the Asian multilateral trade mainstream with the RCEP and the Indo-Pacific Economic Framework; and brings a degree of coherence to its internal polity. The question of when the Ukraine war will end still hangs in the air. Sundeep Waslekar, president, Strategic Foresight Group, writes, "War does not happen merely because of geography, economy or destiny. War results from the choices leaders make. If war is a matter of choice, so can be peace." He lists three possible scenarios, and a role for India.

Our lives are not hostage solely to those macro events. Soroco founder Rohan Murty and tech savant Prasanto K. Roy gaze into the digital crystal ball and foresee positive and negative disruptions. Despite the boom-to-bust graph of cryptocurrency, Murty feels its underlying infrastructure—blockchain—will alter "the status quo". Marking another revolution, former Hyundai Motors India president B.V.R. Subbu says: "Will 2023 become the breakout year for electric two-wheelers? Without a doubt." India will also be a rich fairground of entertainment, producer Siddharth Roy Kapur tells us, with everything from the AR/VR multiverse to OTT to social media to movie theatres and television coexisting—and growing. Many such sharp insights from 15 essayists liven this issue, telling us why 2023 carries as much peril as promise.

(Aroon Purie)